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1930, ‘Peace, Order and Good Government’

The Lahore Conspiracy Case began in court after Bhagat Singh was arrested on 8 April 1929 with B.K. Dutt for throwing smoke bombs in the central Legislative Assembly in New Delhi, ‘to make the deaf hear’.[1] B.K. Dutt was a Bengali. A number of Bengalis had been involved in Lahore,[2] and the HSRA had been recruiting followers of Anushilan Samiti.[3] The action by Bhagat Singh and B.K. Dutt was designed to demonstrate their opposition to the continued British occupation of India.

Police investigations showed that members of the HSRA were behind the December 1928 assassination of a British official J.P. Saunders, who had been mistaken for his boss, J.A. Scott, the superintendent of police. Scott had been in charge when the nationalist figure, Lala Lajpat Rai, who had lived in Lahore since 1880 and had studied law at its Government College, was assaulted by police batons while marching against the Simon Commission in October 1928, where as one writer said ‘the public will have apparently none of the play’.[4] When Lajpat Rai died in the hospital on 17 November 1928, his death at the hands of the Punjab police gave rise to a new round of political violence. It was in fact the event that transformed the political landscape of India. Bhagat Singh set out to avenge the death of Lala Lajpat Rai. This is how J.P. Saunders came to be shot on 17 December 1928. Bhagat Singh became immensely popular. In her recent work on the Lahore Conspiracy Case,[5] Taylor Sherman considers Bhagat Singh’s trial in the context of India’s nationalist revolutionary movements of the time, the hunger strike undertaken, and then followed by his hasty execution. She observes how when the Punjab police put together the Lahore Conspiracy Case in 1929 ‘to charge twenty-five members of the HSRA, [Hindustan